

The Decision I Need

One fork, the argument for it, and the counter-argument expected

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The question. A March 2026 theory paper proves the effect I study can go either way, with no experiments in it. I have the experiments, a rule a practitioner can apply, and results that say the theory is right about one half of its claim while its boundary needed correcting on the other. **Is that a paper worth publishing, or does it read as a follow-up to someone else's result?**

Why I think it stands.

1. Their theorem says the direction is knowable. It gives no way to know it: its conditions could not be evaluated on any of 26 real datasets under two different estimators. My rule needs one number every deployed system already has, last year's approval rate, and it tracks their theoretical quantity at 0.85 across 150 populations. They proved the answer exists; I built the instrument that reads it.
1. The instrument is validated the hard way: sixteen predictions registered with pass marks before the data existed, ten failures published uncorrected, the recent seals timestamped into the Bitcoin blockchain. The one standing doubt, whether it is truly the rate doing the predicting, was resolved this week by a sealed test on Brazilian census data: the rival reading scored 5 of 10, the rate scored 8.
1. The work corrects the theory as well as using it. Their group-level prediction held in all 45 populations I measured that way, but my sealed test moved their regime boundary: it is the kind of method that matters, not attribute blindness. Appendices do not correct the papers they depend on.

The objection I expect. That this is the empirical appendix to their theory. My answer: a result that cannot be applied to data has not been applied by me. This is a demonstration that it cannot be applied, plus a substitute that can, plus a correction their side must absorb. I would rather hear now if that distinction is too fine.

What I would want you to press me on. I withdrew two headline results when my own guard exposed them, and my strongest sealed pass says "suggestive, not significant" in print. The method that forced those admissions is the part of this work I would most like judged.

The smaller decisions, venue, title, and contacting the theory authors, are on the handout's last page. Scale, for reference: 67 populations, 8 data sources, 5 countries, an 18-page draft, 55 automated checks tying every number to stored results.